

REVIEW ARTICLE

UNWARRANTED CONFIDENCE: A CRITICAL REVIEW OF *THE POVERTY OF ANTI-REALISM*

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THE POVERTY OF ANTI-REALISM: CRITICAL PERSPECTIVES ON POSTMODERNIST PHILOSOPHY OF HISTORY. Edited by Tor Egil Følrand and Branko Mitrović. Lexington Books, 2023. Pp. xxvi, 220.

ABSTRACT

The Poverty of Anti-Realism: Critical Perspectives on Postmodernist Philosophy of History, edited by Tor Egil Følrand and Branko Mitrović, celebrates the new dawn of historical realism, which it claims supersedes the erroneous and harmful anti-realism. The volume indeed contributes to reinvigorating the debate surrounding realism and anti-realism and draws attention to a relatively neglected philosophical approach in the philosophy of historiography: realism. However, both the tone and content of this New Historical Realism leave much to be desired. The book displays unwarranted confidence regarding the quality of its content and its grasp of philosophical issues. Many of the essays in this volume exhibit a lack of understanding about the basic issues of realism and anti-realism and are riddled with conceptual confusions. Philosophical notions such as anti-realism, irrealism, postmodernism, idealism, and constructivism are used casually and even interchangeably. Although there are some glimmers of light and more measured approaches in the book, its broad-brush categories are premised on an us-against-them view of the scholarly debate, presenting the rival anti-realistic position simplistically as detrimental, deficient, and wholly objectionable. I end my article with a plea for prudent scholarship and reviewing in the philosophy of historiography and philosophy more generally.

Keywords: historical realism, scientific realism, anti-realism, pluralism, idealism, reviewing, prudent scholarship

The contributors to *The Poverty of Anti-Realism: Critical Perspectives on Postmodernist Philosophy of History* can, in principle, be lauded for bringing attention to an underrepresented topic in the philosophy of historiography, although hardly in the philosophy of science. They are correct in their view that explicitly or implicitly anti-realist approaches have been the main current in the philosophy of historiography for some decades now. It is not clear why this is the case. Perhaps it is because historiography is more congenial to anti-realist arguments or anti-realist arguments are simply stronger. Maybe it is because no one has yet invested enough time and effort into developing conceptually crisp arguments in

support of realism in the philosophy of historiography. It is also possible that there is some bias in the field, making many of its practitioners myopic. Perhaps this is the book to find out!

The book's title already signals its approach to its subject matter. Its use of the term "poverty" suggests that anti-realism is inadequate and lacks the conceptual, explanatory, and argumentative resources needed to sustain its claims. This creates expectations regarding both the content of the book's realist line of reasoning and the method that should be used to settle the score. Naturally, the book's contributors are not expected to succumb to the very pitfalls they attribute to their opponents. Further, in philosophy more generally, we wish to play a game of reasoning in which the focus is on arguments and their merits.

That said, it is worth recalling that, some decades ago, it was not uncommon for authors to be cocky about the quality of their own reasoning and rude about others' thinking in philosophical debates. Unfortunately, I see signs of a similar approach in the current debate about realism after the emergence of New Historical Realism. My primary motivation for writing this review article is to highlight this tendency and to express my wish that we do not descend into the rabbit hole of aggressive, demeaning, and boastful rhetoric. It is corrosive to the goals of the philosophical enterprise, which aims to enhance understanding and dialogue. There is another interest that I must balance with the first: I am worried about not only the tone of this discourse but also the quality of the philosophical advances in this book. Naturally, part of philosophical discussion involves pointing out mistakes and errors, but this should be done without participants' egos hijacking the debate.

While I do my best here to balance these two aims, it is my view that *The Poverty of Anti-Realism* contains too many unwarranted claims and too much unwarranted confidence. A strategy frequently used by the book's contributors entails obfuscating the issues at hand and, at times, engaging in what can only be described as a kind of gaslighting before attempting to "have their cake and eat it too," so to speak. In the end, the book is a failed attempt to settle the score argumentatively; regrettably, it does not itself manage to avoid the "poverty" accusation that it has directed at its perceived enemies. I end my article with a plea for prudent practice in reviewing and philosophical debate more generally. Before that, I delve into the topics of *The Poverty of Anti-Realism* and their philosophical context and significance.

VILLAINS AND HEROES

The Poverty of Anti-Realism canvasses a vivid, even dramatic, story about the contemporary philosophy of historiography. This is best exemplified in Tor Egil Følrand and Branko Mitrović's introduction, which is titled "Being Realist About History," but it is also apparent in other contributions. It prophesizes that we are at the new renaissance of realism, which will save us from the dark ages of anti-realism. This story is black and white, containing clear villains and heroes.

The villains are sometimes called "anti-realists," sometimes "idealists," sometimes "postmodernists," and other times "constructivists." Their crime is predominantly intellectual. We are told that they "have gotten their philosophy wrong,"

“fight straw men” (ix), and are logically challenged in their argumentation. We are also told that their philosophy rests on “a poor foundation” such that their success can be explained only institutionally—that is, the (mis)use of power is tied to “the role of leading journals in setting the tone and agenda and determining whose voices will be transmitted most loudly and who will hardly be heard at all” (xvii).

Yet, the anti-realists’ crime is not only intellectual. It also has to do with the harm done to innocent bystanders, such as practicing historians, who have fortunately “left anti-realism by the wayside” (viii): “It is widely rejected among practicing historians” (183).¹ Førlund and Mitrović claim that “some versions of anti-realism are quite harmless” (ix), implying that some versions are quite harmful. In fact, they argue, certain “anti-realist views are impediments to comprehending the past” (vii). One contributor, Ian Verstegen, claims that anti-realism “undermines the historical enterprise itself” (155). Mitrović suggests that anti-realism is guilty of three vices: “unpersuasive arguments,” “off-putting partisanship,” and oppressive “political implications” (183–84).

Anti-realists’ “postmodernism” is singled out as an approach that “has inflicted immense damage on the philosophy of history by reducing the entire discipline to unproductive efforts to show that the past did not happen or that it cannot be known” (67). For this reason, anti-realism should be (deservedly) left “on the shelf to be forgotten” (ix). The reader is told that anti-realism also aligns with oppressive politics or is maybe even itself a form of oppressive politics (198–202).

It is obvious that the philosophy of historiography needs rescuing from these villains! Fortunately, the white cavalry of the philosophy of historiography has arrived on the scene: New Historical Realists, who take us to the new promised land of realism. Førlund and Mitrović are on a crusade: “Our mission is to save the philosophy of history from itself” (ix).

What can they do for us in practice? The main point is that “realism is a prerequisite for anyone attempting to discuss works written in the past” (xvi). It is a pity that the authors do not clearly show how proper discussions about historiography are now finally enabled. By reversing the vices of anti-realism, adopting New Historical Realism promises to bring a plenitude of other beneficial consequences and intellectual virtues: getting philosophy right, being logically impeccable, and resting on firm philosophical foundations. It also aspires to make the philosophy of history coherent again (67). It can then be expected to be even and objective in its portrayal and treatment of rival positions, unlike petty anti-realists. Realism is also needed to fight the oppressive politics supported by anti-realists (199).

If the book is meant to focus on the argumentative merits of its position, it is strange that the authors so often, even beyond the Manichaeian introduction, reassure the reader that their rivals produce “poor and unconvincing arguments” and that their arguments are of “poor quality” (191). Do the contributors not trust that their own arguments can convince readers on the basis of their intellectual merit? Why do they seemingly require an additional *performative* layer of encouragement? I have my suspicions. It seems that New Historical Realists need enemies

1. These empirical statements are made without any evidence or even recognition that evidential examination is required to determine whether they are warranted.

to amplify their own significance; they want to be seen as saviors against all that is deemed bad and harmful and that currently, in their view, drives the agenda in the field.

In any case, with this kind of scene-setting, New Historical Realists have raised the bar pretty high for themselves. The reader has every right to expect that their own writing will embody this notion of high and impartial scholarship. Let us, then, get acquainted with this virtuous intellectual approach and see what it can offer. Although there is individual variation in the contributions to this edited collection, I take it that the authors are generally committed to what the book's title says: the poverty of anti-realism and thus, generally, the benefits of some version of realism. In what follows, I examine the nature of this realism and the grounds on which the contributors advocate it.

WE ARE WHAT WE ARE NOT

The book is composed of three main sections: part 1, "Philosophical Contexts," contains chapters by Adam Timmins and Veli Virmajoki; part 2, "Critiques," contains chapters by Mitrović, Førland, Timmins, and David Weberman; and part 3, "Political Implications," contains chapters by Versteegen, Mitrović (again), and Førland (again). It is evident that this New Historical Realism is primarily Mitrović and Førland's project, for these advocates of realism are responsible for five of the book's ten chapters.

While Mitrović calls for "open debate and invite[s] the advocates of anti-realism to respond to counterarguments" (184), the reader is in for a surprise. One encounters rhetoric that does not invite open debate,² at least if "open debate" means inclusivity, transparency, respect, and constructiveness regarding one's interlocutors.³ Given that anti-realists are scolded for fighting straw men, one would expect New Historical Realists to feel the urge to be fair and balanced in their analyses of rival philosophical positions. Regrettably, they do not seem to see the beam in their own eyes, but instead, they provide very approximate and rough accounts. Might this be a projection of their own shortcomings? In any case, New Historical Realists identify themselves in opposition to their imagined enemies, in turn largely defining themselves by what they are not.

In his historical overview in "Idealism in Historical Theory, 1970–2020," Timmins characterizes his approach as "somewhat broad-brushed" (3). The book as a whole follows a similar pattern: Idealists, postmodernists, anti-realists, and constructivists are taken as synonymous. In Timmins's contribution, the reader is further told that postmodernists, poststructuralists, and the philosophy of Hayden White "form a homogenous mass of relativism" (4).⁴ "Homogenous

2. On a more positive note regarding openness and dialogue, Mitrović and Førland invited me to the "Past the Post: Philosophy of History After Postmodernism" conference, which was held at the University of Oslo in May 2024. I thank them for their generosity in hosting me.

3. Consider, for instance, Førland's claim that I "must be described as a postmodernist" (82; emphasis added). No grounds for this bold claim follow, and no definition of postmodernism is provided.

4. For anyone interested in relativism, see James W. McAllister, "Relativism," in *A Companion to the Philosophy of Science*, ed. W. H. Newton-Smith (Blackwell, 2000), 405–7.

mass of relativism"! Irrealism, strong constructivism, and "fig-leaf rationality" (3, 13) are thrown into the mix without much qualification. Timmins suggests that idealism is a covering concept for all of these accounts on the grounds of a negative characterization: Everything that is not realism is idealism. This might indeed work if three issues were explicit or established: (1) what exactly realism is; (2) that all these rival approaches are compatible with one another; and (3) that realism is necessarily incompatible with all these accounts. Unfortunately, none of these issues is made explicit, although one finds some attempts to define realism later in the book. As a result, we end up with an intellectual potpourri.

Idealism itself has a rich and venerable history, and I do not think that there is anything inherently wrong with being an idealist; naturally, the merit of any argument for it depends on its exact specification. Certainly, it is not warranted to say that anti-realism coincides with idealism. Anti-realism is not a small and marginal approach, and it does not form a homogenous group in philosophy. Many celebrated philosophers of the twentieth century were anti-realists in some sense: logical positivism and empiricism, C. G. Hempel, W. V. O. Quine, Hilary Putnam, Thomas Kuhn, Larry Laudan, Bas van Fraassen, Paul Hoyningen-Huene, and so on. To this list we can add metaphysicians, such as David Armstrong, who is anti-realist about universals. None of these figures can reasonably be counted as idealists. It is equally unwarranted, and even absurd, to leap from anti-realism to postmodernism. Although it is conceivable that postmodernists are anti-realists, the reverse does not hold; the latter typically commit to the rationality of science, for instance, but the former do not.

Further, anti-realists normally accept that historical accounts may provide knowledge and understanding of the past. They may even accept that practitioners succeed in getting things right. The key question is how to determine what being right means and how correctness can be ascertained in science and history. Addressing these concerns requires careful analysis and profound understanding of twentieth- and twenty-first-century philosophy. Unfortunately, this kind of analysis does not come across in *The Poverty of Anti-Realism*. Not even idealists would deny the possibility of historical knowledge. In the case of the most extreme version of idealism, such as Berkeley's subjective idealism, reality would be wholly spiritual, but this would have no consequences for everyday or historical beliefs. Furthermore, a constructivist does not need to think that what is constructed is not real in the material and tangible sense that resists our practices and theorizing; it only means that the object was not given prior to construction. My watch is very real, but it is constructed, for example. Furthermore, it is difficult to find scholars who think that "constructions are free-floating" (7) (whatever that means) or that there is no difference between the past and what historians write about it. Still, Timmins seems to think it is necessary to state that these commitments are rejected by realists.

Timmins's brush is simply too broad to shed light conceptually or historically. Maybe he is emulating Jackson Pollock's style of drip painting. The irony of this kind of impressionist intellectual history dawns on the reader along the way. We can, of course, understand Timmins's text as a creative construction of the past and be happy that at least a new historiographical colligation has been produced.

But should we accept this as a depiction of the historian-independent past *as it really was* (that is, in a way that is in line with the realists' philosophical commitments)? Is this really "the *real past*," which has been reproduced despite its incoherence, rather than one out of many possible accounts? If not, what kind of claim to "reality" does this historiographical account possess?

Timmins describes his effort to package five decades of the theory and philosophy of history under the label of idealism as "a bit like . . . trying [to] nail jelly to the wall" (4). I can only sympathize with this difficult task, but it also leads me to wonder: Why do it if this kind of broad-brush jelly-nailing just does not stick? Timmins fares better in a more narrowly focused analysis of White's thinking. In my opinion, Timmins should have stuck to a more careful and analytical approach and avoided any unnecessary polemics. He could have analyzed "idealism" or "postmodernism" through certain authors, such as Keith Jenkins.⁵ This likely would have resulted in a more meaningful dialogue between various interlocutors in philosophy of historiography.

Timmins's first contribution contains a number of other claims that raise eyebrows. He suggests that it is self-evident and commonsense that the past exists somewhere (5). A few words are needed to explain where exactly and in what form this past now resides. Can we access it? A reference to some advanced physics does not really cut it in the context of the philosophy of historiography.

WHAT IS REALISM?

Let us then take the bull by its horns and try to get some clarity about realism. What is realism? How could it be defined? Naturally, there are a lot of different formulations of realism. For example, the well-known philosopher of science and scientific realist Howard Sankey has defined scientific realism through the following (necessary) realist tenets:

1. *Axiological realism*: the aim of science is to discover the truth about the world, and scientific progress consists in advance toward that aim. . . .
2. *Theoretical entity realism*: the unobservable theoretical entities postulated by scientific theories are to be conceived as real, genuinely existing entities. . . .
3. *Metaphysical realism*: the world investigated by science is an objective reality that exists independently of human thought. . . .
4. *Correspondence theory of truth*: truth consists in correspondence between a claim about the world and the way the world is. . . .
5. *Objectivity of truth*: theories or claims about the world are made true (or false) by the way things are in the mind-independent, objective reality investigated by science.⁶

5. However, ironically, Jenkins also bluntly stated, "I'm a *realist*" ("Nobody Does It Better": Radical History and Hayden White," *Rethinking History* 12, no. 1 [2008]: 60).

6. Howard Sankey, "What Is Scientific Realism?," *Divinatio* 12 (2000): 103–20. Other optional conditions are also listed.

Compare this to Anjan Chakravartty's entry on scientific realism in the *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, which also discusses its neo-Kantian rival in passing:

Metaphysically, realism is committed to the mind-independent existence of the world investigated by the sciences. . . . More common rejections of mind-independence stem from neo-Kantian views of the nature of scientific knowledge, which deny that the world of our experience is mind-independent, even if (in some cases) these positions accept that the world in itself does not depend on the existence of minds. The contention here is that the world investigated by the sciences—as distinct from “the world in itself” (assuming this to be a coherent distinction)—is in some sense dependent on the ideas one brings to scientific investigation, which may include, for example, theoretical assumptions and perceptual training.⁷

One could find additional descriptions from numerous other authors, but there is an approximate general agreement on how to understand (scientific) realism, which is captured by the above two accounts.

In his contribution titled “Saving Historical Reality (Even If We Construct It),” Weberman expresses skepticism about the value of scientific realism in the philosophy of historiography. According to Weberman, the debates of scientific realism and anti-realism are not helpful because scientific realism focuses on the ontological status of “non-observable phenomena” (114). It is correct that this particular issue is not directly relevant in the way discussed in scientific realism.⁸ However, it is worth noting that historiography also discusses issues and things that are not observable, such as colligatory notions, past societies, and past phenomena at large.

The crux of the matter is that, with some caveats and exceptions, the core claims are the same in both scientific realism and realism about historiography. Furthermore, historiography is a scientific discipline that studies the past; that is, it is a systematic and professional practice that attempts to produce knowledge of the past. Consequently, it is worth considering the philosophy of historiography as a subfield of the philosophy of science. This further supports taking scientific realism seriously in the debates about realism and anti-realism.

Now, the task is to determine what the realism promulgated by New Historical Realists is. The first thing to notice is that, with the exception of Virmajoki, they do not seem to have consulted scholarship on scientific realism. Even so, we might say that the fundamental concepts in historical realism are the mind-independence of the research object, the objectivity of the research object, and the correspondence notion of truth to the mind-independent world, including the assumption that there is one way the world is. Since it is impossible to conduct a thorough study of realism, a modified version of Sankey's fifth tenet catches the essence of it and serves our purposes: “claims about the world are made true (or false) by the way things are in the mind-independent, objective reality investigated by

7. Anjan Chakravartty, “Scientific Realism,” *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* (Summer 2017 Edition), ed. Edward N. Zalta, last modified 12 June 2017, <https://plato.stanford.edu/archives/sum2017/entries/scientific-realism>.

8. Another example of a nontransferrable discussion is the no miracles argument, which is discussed in Virmajoki's essay and for which I do not see any appropriate application in the philosophy of historiography.

science” (or historiography). The phrases “the way things are” and “the way the world is” connote the mind-independence of these things and the existence of a single truth about the world. This can be roughly encapsulated by saying that, for realists generally, there is one way the world is and we are able to discover it. If any of these conditions is dropped, one’s status as a realist becomes questionable.

Unfortunately, in *The Poverty of Anti-Realism*, readers do not find a shared line of thinking regarding realism, which is perhaps not so strange in an edited collection. Fortunately, almost all of the authors have contributed something to this definitional challenge, although many accounts are, in fact, incompatible with one another. I focus now on the available characterizations of New Historical Realism.

TENETS OF NEW HISTORICAL REALISM

Timmins provides a reasonable starting point for identifying the tenets of New Historical Realism, and his perspective coincides with what is stated above about scientific realism. He argues that there are three key ingredients to any kind of realism: “existence,” “independence,” and “accessibility” (5). In other words, realists believe that the objects of historiographical research exist, they are independent of the historian, and the historian has access to them. This provides a point of departure, although it is still a rather limited characterization of realism.

According to Mitrović, the requirement of complete description and absolute objectivity is wrongly associated with realism. In particular, he argues against Putnam’s characterization of metaphysical realism as committed to the idea that “there is exactly one true and complete description of ‘the way the world is.’”⁹ Mitrović’s reason for opposing this is that we can use various languages and conceptualizations to describe objects (54). It is worth pondering this more closely, as this statement—and, more importantly, its compatibility with realism—is far from obvious.

It is correct that realists do not necessarily need to think that there is one total, comprehensive, or “complete” description of the world, although many scientific realists perhaps think that this should be the case. Consider the dream of the theory of everything, which would presumably explain fundamentally and definitively how the world functions, from the most minute issues to the extremely large scale. In the realist’s framework, it provides a uniquely true description and not just one of many possible ones. Naturally, Putnam does not deny that a world could be described in English, Norwegian, Serbian, and so on, or that we can use various conceptualizations. The essence of Putnam’s point is that metaphysical realism assumes that there is one truth about the world—that is, a description of the world that is uniquely correct because it portrays the world as it is without any subject-sided influence. If a description provides an alternative “truth,” or if there is an incompatible description about the same subject matter, then one description must be false.

9. Hilary Putnam, *Reason, Truth and History* (Cambridge University Press, 1981), 49.

Problematically, Mitrović and Følrand's "realism" enables there to be several equally good descriptions of the world, and it even seems to require this. Let us then consider whether we could combine realism with descriptive pluralism, which New Historical Realists are calling for. As implied above, realism is typically related to ontological and descriptive monism.¹⁰ In other words, it is associated with the belief that there is only one way the world is. When we "get it right" in the realist framework, we produce a representation of this world, characterized by a match or correspondence between what is represented and what does the representing. The problem is that pluralism normally correlates with anti-realism either on the grounds that the world or past does not have one form or structure independent of our conceptualization (leading to ontological anti-realism) or on the grounds that we are not able to describe it for some reason (leading to epistemological anti-realism). For these reasons, descriptive pluralism is naturally associated with the anti-realist standpoint on the sciences.

Regarding realism, the key question is thus whether there could be an interpretation that allows for equally good and yet incompatible descriptions of the same subject matter. That is, can there be true descriptions that contradict each other? To begin with, Weberman's argument against anti-realism fails. As I argue below, his formulations appear as some kind of epistemological anti-realism despite his opposite aspirations. Discounting some genuine postmodernists and skeptics, which are few in number, he does not seem to realize that anti-realists also call for evaluations and evidential standards. The existence of evidential standards is not the real sticking point. Instead, the debate concerns what they should be and whether they take us to the "real," "true," or "really real," as realists suggest.

Most anti-realists commit to the idea of objectivity, but of course, how objectivity ought to be defined is another matter. Weberman's use of perspectival objectivity, which he has borrowed from Amartya Sen, is very interesting but also very underdeveloped. The idea of perspectivity is more congenial with anti-realism than with realism, because it entails that our descriptions are always and irreducibly generated from some angle. Because there is always a perspective, no description can correspond to a perspectiveless reality. Finally, the claim that it is "pretty commonsensical" (130) to compare the accuracy and truth of our narratives and theses with the "past reality" sounds simply esoteric. I, for one, would be keen to visit the temporal laboratory or time machine that enables this kind of comparison. To use traces from the past to license or discredit claims about it is to engage in an inferential practice between statements, requiring one to judge whether evidence either supports or undermines them. It is not a matter of comparing one's account with the past itself, unless "past reality" instead means something different that is absent in one respect and yet present in another, so far unstipulated, sense. Or maybe "comparison" is used metaphorically here.

Let us then consider more closely what conceptual options New Historical Realism might have in order to hold on to the view that there are several equally good descriptions—that is, descriptive pluralism. First, there is a trivial view that

10. See, for example, Hasok Chang, "Is Pluralism Compatible with Scientific Realism?," in *The Routledge Handbook of Scientific Realism*, ed. Juha Saatsi (Routledge, 2017), 176–86.

has no consequences for realism or anti-realism of any kind (as long as one is not a reductionist): (1) Alternative descriptions are not in competition—that is, they do not have such logical relations that make descriptions incompatible and can therefore be true at the same time. This can take at least two different modes. One is that we are simply describing two different objects—for instance, my desk and my latest conference presentation. It is difficult to imagine how descriptions of these two objects could cancel each other out. Another is the case of descriptions of the same object in distinct frameworks and with different cognitive interests, including noncognitive interests—for example, a physical description of the iconic Stool 60 composed of microparticles, a sociological description of it as an artifact in family life in Finland, and an aesthetic description of it as a celebrated piece of design. All of these descriptions can stand next to one another without creating any problems unless one is a reductionist who wishes to reduce everything to some foundational and “real” elements or master framework. There are few such scholars left currently, as the problems of reductionism are substantial. The problem is that Mitrović’s marriage of realism with materialism requires reductionism in order to make it conceptually coherent, which then makes him an anti-realist about historical phenomena. I explain this further below.

There is a second way for a realist to be a pluralist: (2) Every description corresponds to a different set of *mind-independent facts*. It is challenging to spell out what this might mean. Is it the situation in which an account (a) of my Stool 60 composed of some microparticles and an account of it (b) as a sociological object and (c) as a colligation of aesthetic qualities correspond to a different set of mind-independent facts? The suggestion is then either that there are ready-made sets of facts that correspond to propositions in any frame that we might choose to use or that any use of any framework always creates a new set of facts. This is literally ontological pluralism.

No realist would commit to such a view of “alternative facts” because this casts serious doubts about the mind-independence of the research object. This option instead makes facts language- or frame-dependent. Further, this would mean either inflating ontologies indefinitely or giving up on the premise that there is one way the world is or that there is *one* truth about the world. In ontological pluralism, there are many, perhaps even innumerable ways the world is, and therefore, the world is indeed radically open to descriptions. Our perspectives, interests, languages, and concepts in part determine what we make of this world. Consider the debates on scientific revolutions in the history and philosophy of science, wherein Kuhn famously claimed that “after a revolutions scientists work in a different world.”¹¹ The literal realist reading, admitting alternative ontologies after revolutions, would slip into a form of idealism according to which any radical theory change creates its own set of facts. Admittedly, there are some who argue for both realism and ontological pluralism, but the integration requires, by their

11. Thomas S. Kuhn, *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions*, 2nd ed., enlarged (University of Chicago Press, 1970), 135.

own admission, “a strongly revisionist account of the very notions of truth and reality.”¹² These revisionist notions are not realism as it has become known.

There is, then, a third option: (3) We admit that the object of research is *not mind-independent but depends on our conceptualization*, which is where the second option in effect succumbed. This is fully in line with descriptive pluralism, but is it also in line with realism? This third option is not (ontological) realism because it abandons the idea of the mind-independence of the world. There is a rich and interesting history for this kind of thinking. In modern philosophy, John Dewey, Rudolf Carnap, Kuhn, and Putnam, and, in the philosophy of historiography, Arthur Danto and Paul Roth, among others, have advocated the idea of frame-dependence of our descriptions without casting doubt on the authority of the sciences or historiography. Following Carnap’s discussion in *The Logical Syntax of Language*,¹³ it is fully meaningful to ask whether twenty-seven is a prime number within the framework of mathematics. To ask whether it is “really” a prime number does not add anything to this. “Really” and “real” are superfluous. Further, asking whether prime numbers exist is not meaningful but expresses a confusion because it is an attempt to ask a question outside any framework.

Naturally, there is also an epistemological version available that says that, although there is the way the world is, it is beyond some kind of transcendental limit and our capabilities for description. This epistemological anti-realism says that we cannot know or describe how the world is, even if it exists in some shape. By contrast, ontological anti-realism denies that these entities are “Self-Identifying,” to use Putnam’s phrase.¹⁴ In this case, it is thus not only that we cannot know them but also that they do not exist independently of our conceptualizations as self-identifying. Both epistemological and ontological anti-realism enable descriptive pluralism. But neither of them is realism (although a combination of epistemological anti-realism cum ontological realism is conceptually possible).

In brief, if one claims that there are incompatible but equally good or true descriptions of the “way the world is,” one departs from realism (at least in the epistemological sense, and possibly also in the ontological sense). In other words, if what there is depends on our conceptualization, frameworks, or something like that, then there is no mind-independent (and discourse-independent) object of research. All descriptions and accounts of the world are dependent on someone’s or something’s conceptualizations. This is not realism by any standard understanding. For example, Kuhn thought along these lines when he stated that comprehending nature always requires some conceptual scheme and when he conceptualized the development of the history of science through historicized Kantian

12. Chang, “Is Pluralism Compatible with Scientific Realism?,” 176. See also Hasok Chang, *Realism for Realistic People: A New Pragmatist Philosophy of Science* (Cambridge University Press, 2022). Symptomatically, Paul Hoyningen-Huene and K. Brad Wray noted that Chang’s “realism is, in effect, very close to what has customarily been called anti-realism” (“Discussion Note on Hasok Chang: *Realism for Realistic People*,” *Journal for General Philosophy of Science* 56 [2025]: 275).

13. Rudolf Carnap, *The Logical Syntax of Language*, trans. Amethe Smeaton (Routledge, 1937), 277–334. See also Rudolf Carnap, “Empiricism, Semantics, and Ontology,” *Revue Internationale de Philosophie* 4, no. 11 (1950): 20–40.

14. Putnam, *Reason, Truth and History*, 53–54.

categories.¹⁵ The conclusion is that pluralism is not compatible with realism by any accepted understanding in contemporary philosophy. New Historical Realists must think that there is one mind-independent past and that being correct about it means forming a *uniquely correct* description or (compatible) descriptions in the sense of correspondence between the representation(s) of the past and the past.

NEW HISTORICAL REALISTS ARE COVERT ANTI-REALISTS

Let us return to New Historical Realism and to its advocates' formulations of realism. According to Mitrović,

Different presentations of the same building (different sets of drawings) based on different conventions can still describe the building with the same level of accuracy. It seems pointless to debate which one, out of a number of different surveys, describes the building as it actually is. At most, since different surveys have different levels of accuracy, one can say that a given survey shows the building the way it "actually is" in the sense that it is more accurate than other surveys. Also, there is no such a thing as a definite or a complete survey of a building: the architectural historian who conducts the survey pays attention to the details that he or she considers important. (55)

It is difficult to understand this passage if we are required to stay within the realist framework. The paragraph contains at least the following statements: (1) there are many equally accurate descriptions ("the same level of accuracy"); (2) it is "pointless to debate" what the object is beyond these descriptions; (3) any description reflects the interests of the describer (that is, what the describer "considers important"). It therefore seems to follow that (4) there is no definitive account, although it is difficult to square this with the statement that a description can depict how an object "actually is." Is this a sheer empty formulation that plays with the language of realism without engaging the content of realism? Put briefly, this paragraph states that all descriptions depend on the interests and perspectives of the describer and that there is no description-independent way the world is. This is anti-realism.

There are a number of similarly inexplicable statements both regarding what New Historical Realists are said not to be (anti-realist, postmodernists, constructivists) and in their self-prescribed framework of realism. Their frequent references to correspondence are mysterious. For example, after claiming that any description depends on *subjective judgment*, Mitrović adds that "this does not mean that the survey cannot be accurate in the sense of its correspondence to the building. It is accurate or inaccurate relative to the properties of the building the architectural historian has decided to document" (56). What is this correspondence in the situation? How can there be correspondence? What is this a correspondence between? Is it a correspondence between the object/past/world as it is given and the description provided? If this is the case, then it cancels out any description that is in tension with the one that corresponds to the object. It is notable that accuracy is also relative to the historian's interest and judgment, and not only to

15. Thomas S. Kuhn, *The Road Since Structure: Philosophical Essays, 1980–1993*, ed. James Conant and John Haugeland (University of Chicago Press, 2000), 104.

the object described, another stipulation that does not sit well with the tenets of realism. Is the correspondence relation instead between a description-dependent fact and a description, which would disqualify realism and the realistic notion of truth? One possibility is idealism because an idealist can accept a correspondence theory of truth and think that a correspondence consists in the relation between a statement and its spiritually constituted facts. But a realist (and a materialist too) should certainly deny this. Quite correctly, Sankey took care to state that a condition of realism is correspondence to mind-independent facts. No coherent account emerges from Mitrović here.

A charitable reading is that Mitrović is an anti-realist, and even a pragmatist, because he accepts that any account provided reflects the historian's perspective and values (and not the world as it is independent of any historian). It could also be anti-realism in the rarer guise of subjectivism; according to Mitrović, "the survey necessarily depends on the historian's subjective judgment" (56).

The dispute between realism and anti-realism often concerns what can be concluded based on scientific evidence. The history of science provides a rich repository for discussion. Larry Laudan's classic article titled "A Confutation of Convergent Realism" argues convincingly that theories whose central terms refer have not always been successful and that, vice versa, theories that have been successful have failed to refer.¹⁶ A failure to refer despite empirical success led to the conclusion that empirical success is not a reliable guide to what exists and to the truth about the world. A famous example is Georg Ernst Stahl's phlogiston chemistry, which explained combustion by the theoretical postulation that phlogiston is released into the air when an object burns. This theory was successful, but science has since concluded that there is no phlogiston, and therefore, the term "phlogiston" does not refer despite the fact that, earlier on, the phlogiston theory explained empirical phenomena rather well.

To the horror of realists, the correspondence theory idealist would say that both key terms—"phlogiston" and its subsequent theory, "oxygen"—in fact refer but that they refer to a different set of facts, as if the world literally changes as theory changes. If we accept that the terms of descriptively equally adequate, but incompatible, theories refer and correspond to the world, then, for Mitrović, the only remaining option appears to be that the world itself and its ontology literally change in scientific transitions. Again, this is far beyond the scope of any known realism.

It is also unwarranted to attempt to settle what "really" exists beyond what scientific evidence tells us, but the realist's approach and language implies something like this. Most of the entities that were once thought to exist, and to which the scientific terms of earlier generations were thought to refer, are no longer believed to exist as such because their descriptions have failed—that is, they have been proved evidentially untenable or false. It is notable that this is the situation in the history of the sciences, wherein descriptions tend to be more stable than in historiography. When these observations are carried over to the history of

16. Larry Laudan, "A Confutation of Convergent Realism," *Philosophy of Science* 48, no. 1 (1981): 19–49.

historiography, we risk flooding historical ontology with all current, failed, and imaginary histories. At the same time, this is not far from what F. R. Ankersmit earlier described as narrative holism emulating “intellectual alcoholism”: more writing just creates more of it without a convergence in sight.¹⁷ Whatever this is philosophically, it is not realism. Perhaps it is postmodernism.

CAN WE HAVE OUR CAKE AND EAT IT TOO?

Interestingly, Mitrović seems to advocate the standpoint that he himself associated with postmodernism. He states that it is meaningless to attribute truth-values to the sets of “propositions that a historical text conveys”: “The sum of all propositions that a historical work conveys is not identical with the sum of all propositions expressed by each individual sentence of its text” (61). Astonishingly, he then further states: “The idea that the content of a historical work is some kind of a holist entity, over and above individual propositions, is common among postmodernist authors” (62). But has he himself just committed to that kind of holism? Is he then also one of the “postmodernists” derided in the book?

Furthermore, Mitrović does not seem to realize that he, in effect, also confirms Putnam’s argument contra (metaphysical) realism. Putnam described his position as internal realism. A Putnamian internal realist thinks that there are several true theories or descriptions of the world and that our belief systems do not correspond to discourse- or mind-independent “states of affairs.”¹⁸ In other words, according to Putnam, objects do not exist independently of their conceptualization, as conceptualizations are needed to cut up the world. One way to express this is to say that there are no self-identifying objects, as above—or, perhaps, there is no given preordained structure of reality. Yet another way to put the matter is to say that we need to predicate—that is, recognize—that something F is something a. When this is done, a concept is introduced or some language is used, including some criteria to apply and identify something as something F. In brief, the concept is used as a classifier. The challenge for the realist in the true sense of the word—that is, a Putnamian type of metaphysical realist—is to explain how we can maintain the distinction between what we judge to be the case and what is allegedly “really” the case.¹⁹ The non-realist says that this notion of “really” is illusory because our only approach to what the case is is through evidence and our judgments. Arguably, not even New Historical Realists have this superhuman access to how things “really are.”

New Historical Realists’ recurring know-it-all attitude is striking. For example, in an article published in the *Journal of the Philosophy of History*, Mitrović declared that nominalism cannot deny that properties, such as redness, have a “counterpart in reality [because it] is then to say that there are no red things

17. F. R. Ankersmit, “Historiography and Postmodernism,” *History and Theory* 28, no. 2 (1989): 138.

18. Putnam, *Reason, Truth and History*, 49–50.

19. *Ibid.*, 71.

whatsoever.”²⁰ This is not so, and he should know that, especially because he has invested so much time on the topic, “having worked on late scholastics for some decades.”²¹ One might suppose that he has put some effort into understanding nominalism in general, including some more recent interpretations of nominalism. And if not, then there is something to learn. While nominalists deny the existence of universals and abstract objects, they accept the *talk* of properties. Predicate nominalism holds that “redness” is just a name or a label, and to be a red object is to apply the term “red” to certain instances. Another form of nominalism, class nominalism, says that “redness” postulates a class of objects. To be a red object is nothing but to belong to a class of red objects, and so on.²² Mitrović’s touted version, according to which “properties are still there, but in things,”²³ could be read as a trope theory, wherein properties are understood as particulars. Yet this approach would be curious in historiography if the intention is to argue that the term “Renaissance,” for example, names individual tokens, as if there were a kind of Renaissance DNA hidden in each particular. A specific piece of furniture, book, or idea, if classified as “Renaissance,” would then be imagined to carry these microscopic particles, and the lack of them would disqualify the object from being “Renaissance.”

If this were an empirical approach, it would enable us to place those objects under our historiographical microscope and identify those tiny particles by looking at whether or not this piece can be found. Yet, naturally, as a metaphysical theory of nominalism, this is not a possible approach. A pragmatist wonders what’s the point, as this view does not provide any criteria for the kinds of legitimate descriptions and for their warrants overall. Or is this again unlimited ontological pluralism according to which absolutely any description and any framework creates its own ontology to refer to? In that case, Eric Hobsbawm’s phrase “short twentieth century,”²⁴ for example, would have to denote less-than-a-century-long particles in each object subsumed under his concept. Given the concept’s wide temporal and geographical scope, these particles would be extremely numerous and attached to enormously different kinds of objects. This is a highly mystical view. When New Historical Realists can specify which kinds of description and postulation are warranted in historiography, we should listen. They ought to provide some criteria that distinguish between postulations that are worthy of being believed and those that are not. Before that, repeating the “reality” of historical entities without any specifications for how to distinguish “real” from “unreal” offers little of use.

We have seen that, for many New Historical Realists, a typical approach is to attempt to have one’s cake and eat it too. That is, they declare that realism is correct but then introduce all kinds of qualifications that contradict realism. Despite

20. Branko Mitrović, “Response to Frank Ankersmit, Jouni-Matti Kuukkanen, and Paul Roth,” *Journal of the Philosophy of History* 18, no. 2 (2024): 176.

21. Ibid.

22. A good concise introduction to the problem of universals and nominalism can be found in D. M. Armstrong, *Universals: An Opinionated Introduction* (Westview Press, 1989).

23. Mitrović, “Response,” 176.

24. Eric Hobsbawm, *Age of Extremes: The Short Twentieth Century, 1914–1991* (Abacus, 1995).

this, they happily continue to endorse realism, which has become so alien as a result of various intellectual somersaults that one does not recognize it. Sometimes “realism” has become anti-realism. The tenacity of mind may sometimes be a virtue, but not here. In terms of philosophical discussion, this is frustrating, which is further exacerbated by poor awareness and understanding of scholarship on (scientific) realism.

MATERIALISM, IDEALISM, AND REALISM

I have sympathy for New Historical Realists too. They have probably found it difficult to defend the idea that the past can be described in only one way, although this is exactly what one expects from the commitment to realism. They admit that one should not expect historians to converge on any single view of the past and that the past may always be conceptualized radically differently. Compare this to a scientific realist on physical phenomena. An ontological and epistemological scientific realist would normally expect physics to converge on one true view of the world. If there are disagreements, they are contingent. The same should apply to historiography in the framework of realism.

Now, if the realism of New Historical Realists is reduced to a view that “there is some stuff in the external world” or that “something exists” independently of us, then this is the famous “fig-leaf” realism.²⁵ Who would object to this? Unfortunately, it is so weak that it is hardly worth fighting for. One can, of course, combine epistemological anti-realism with ontological realism and maintain that the historical world exists independently of us in some structured shape and form but that we have no way to know it. But what’s the value of believing that the historical world exists independently in some, and maybe one, form if we cannot say anything about it? It sounds like a pre-analytical belief or prejudice. If realists follow this maxim through, they should attempt to find an absolutely correct view of the past, as determined by the correspondence theory: One’s statement must correspond to how the states of affairs are independent of the historian and his language. This means capturing the given structure and form of the past. Other alternative descriptions, if they are not fully compatible with this true account, must be false and therefore must be rejected. In sum, saying nothing of interest epistemologically and using fig-leaf ontological realism means evading the matter both philosophically and historiographically.

Mitrović appears to think that his commitment to materialism saves him from this philosophical impasse. Perhaps it does, but I doubt he realizes what it saves. His materialism says that things are particles in fields of force: “Past reality is then the past dispositions of particles and fields of force in space-time as well as the changes of these dispositions that occurred in the past. Historical figures, from this point of view, were large clusters of particles that constituted their biological bodies.” How are we then to describe historical phenomena? According to Mitrović, “Napoleon’s *Grande Armée* that crossed the river Niemen on June 24, 1812, was a large number of clusters of particles and fields of force that

25. See Michael Devitt, *Realism and Truth*, 2nd ed. (Princeton University Press, 1997), 22–23.

constituted the soldiers, officers, horses, equipment, artillery, ammunition, and so on.” Although Mitrović admits that this is not the kind of language that historians use, the problem seems to be practical and epistemological, as this kind of description “would require identifying every individual particle.” The position seems to entail that the entities and processes described in the historian’s language do not exist because they are not “physical particles” and “fields of force” (56). For example, we should not talk about President Urho Kekkonen’s ideas and intentions to invite world leaders to Helsinki in 1975 for the Conference on Security and Cooperation in Europe (CSCE). Instead, we should describe them as merely a combination of physical forces and particles interacting in some law-like way, resulting in various complex bodily activities, ink spilling surrounded by Carrara marble (more conventionally known as Finlandia House in Helsinki). And this description may already depart too far from the level of “dispositions of particles and fields of force.” In any case, I look forward to reading this kind of revisionist history.

In brief, for the materialist, nothing corresponds to what the historian describes in the customary historians’ language. The Bolshevik Revolution, for example, is not comprised of fields and forces; it is comprised of Bolsheviks, Mensheviks, revolution, ideas, intentions, fights, victories, suffering, tragedy, drama, and so on. Further, the Renaissance, the Cold War and the CSCE in 1975 are not simply physical forces and particles. Whatever historical phenomena are, they are description-dependent, which is in tension with ontological realism.

This is to say that Mitrović’s materialist realism entails reductionism. Although he may be a realist about physical (not material) phenomena, his materialism turns him, seemingly unbeknownst to him, into an anti-realist about historiographical phenomena. His attempt to deny this in his *Journal of the Philosophy of History* article equals philosophical hand-waving: “The assumption that past events happened and that their happening is independent of historians does not entail that their *descriptions* have to be independent of historians.”²⁶ This kind of strategy does not work. If entities are description-dependent by the historian, then they simply are not independent of the historian and do not exist independently without human-made frames, languages, and conceptual schemes. The key claim is again “independent of historians.” New Historical Realists are not able to make sense of this claim in their frame of realism.

However, in his contribution titled “Irrealism and Historical Theory: A User’s Guide,” fellow realist Timmins states correctly that the realist requires that the past is “fixed and immutable,” which in turn means that “we would need it to have joints: that is, essences and natural kinds” (100). This is indeed so! Overall, I find Timmins’s grasp of realism better in comparison to that of Mitrović and the other contributors, with the possible exception of Virmajoki.

Timmins states that a key tenet of realism is the idea that entities exist, and their nature is what it is (or, in the case of the past, was), independently of how we happen to perceive them, talk about them, or think about them. This is a fair formulation and commitment to the *independence thesis* of the past, which is

26. Mitrović, “Response,” 181.

equivalent to Sankey's third tenet. Virtmajoki reasons along the same lines: "The question of whether our best historiographical works are true descriptions of the mind-independent world is at the core of the realism issue" (42).

However, Timmins strangely declares that "the past can significantly constrain the accuracy of what we write about it" (5). How could that be? My desk surely constrains me if I hit it with my hand, as Bruno Latour and other posthumanists and new materialists repeatedly hammered home. But how could the past do something similar if I write a silly account of history? It won't and cannot. Instead, it is my hope that other historians, and perhaps even institutions in some cases, constrain my practices in a way that is guided by some epistemic rules and values, such as receptiveness to criticism, search for coherence, and respect for evidence.²⁷ This constraining is settled on the level of a community, guided by its rules. Følrand's view that "cognitive values both define and constrain academic historiography" is clearly more perceptive in this regard (87).

Timmins concedes that what there is depends on language or concepts. He claims that, "outside of human conceptual activity, there are no wars or revolutions" (103). However, the realist, who thinks that there is only one way the past is and that the past has "joints" in the true sense of correspondence to the mind-independent facts and structures, should believe that there are wars and revolutions that exist outside the human's (or at least the historian's) conceptual activity. More precisely, accepting that any description of reality entails a concept (such as "war") under which an item is placed implies the following form: some particular *a* is an *F*. For example, Finland's Winter War (1939–1940) is a war. However, as noted, "*F* is *a*" implies that we have a category, *F*, and that *a* is recognized as an *F*. This means that it is possible to mischaracterize *a*. For the realist, this *F* must be given by the world or correspond in some relevant sense of correspondence to the past independently of any conceptual dependence by historians. (Naturally, the realist owes us an explanation of the nature of this correspondence.) We await to hear what categories exist independently of historians' conceptualizations, how we detect them, and whether their number is limited. The upshot is that, if they are not somehow limited in number and are always paired with any description of the past, then their independent "reality" is an empty reclamation.

The reader is left puzzled when, later in this contribution, Timmins implies that it is problematic to talk about World War I as anything but a war (106–7), if it is understood as a colligatory concept or as "an organizing concept." If a description depends on our concepts and language, why would this not be possible? One does not need to possess much artistic talent or conceptual ingenuity to realize that a great number of descriptive options—such as a great human tragedy, the battle of wills, or the bankruptcy of European imperialism—are possible. The past must be either ready-made and conceptualized beyond human conceptualizations or it must not be this way. One cannot have it both ways. In the former case, we have metaphysical realism, and in the latter case, we have anti-realism.

27. David Irving's historiography springs to mind. See Richard J. Evans, *Telling Lies About Hitler: The Holocaust, History and the David Irving Trial* (Verso, 2002).

Timmins adds that, once the past has been conceptualized, “once we have criteria for what a war or revolution is, whether something is a war or revolution depends in no small part on how things actually were” (103). This is correct, although I am not sure what “actually were” is meant to connote here. Who would deny that, once we have criteria for something being an F, deciding the matter depends on whether this criterion is satisfied in light of the available evidence? Historians debate and provide such assessments all the time, although they do so naturally not in harmony with one another. It seems that New Historical Realists confusingly attempt to reach a form of the historical “given,” to use Wilfrid Sellars’s excellent phrase.²⁸ This is the view that the past and its entities are carved out in whatever form they are and exist totally independently of our language, culture, or other interaction.

Perhaps the issue at the heart of this is simply the denial of subjective idealism in favor of materialism: that the world is fundamentally not made of spiritual substances. This much Mitrović and his materialism says. Then, of course, we can say, in a very rough sense, that the world can be described in many ways. But as already stated, this kind of fig-leaf realism is philosophically idle. We need something more than an amorphous view of the world or things that exist in some material-physical sense. Further, hardly anyone is a subjective idealist. Again, realism matters only if it offers workable criteria for determining, among historical posits, which entities exist and which do not.

In his contribution titled “A Deceiving Resemblance: Realism Debates in Philosophy of Science and Philosophy of Historiography,” Virmajoki attempts to shed light on the issues of realism and anti-realism by way of some older debates in the philosophy of science. This is laudable, although it is sometimes difficult to see the relevance of some topics, such as the debate about observational and theoretical terms in science and the so-called no miracles argument. Nevertheless, it is good to explicitly state that matters are complicated and that the complexity requires nuance instead of simplifications. Regarding narratives and tropes, Virmajoki’s positive account seems to be that tropes—and perhaps, by extension, all literary features—are only icing on the cake. He states: “We can notice that what is relevant in historiography is how certain events developed and were connected to each other, not the type of story the events can be seen as constituting” (39).

Virmajoki raises important questions: What is significant in the knowledge that historiography produces? What are the most important entities? Are they narratives, causal chains, dates, persons, and other details, or some more comprehensive syntheses? However, his proposal that the most important objects are sequences of events that matter does not convince the unpersuaded. In the end, Virmajoki looks like a logical positivist who is attempting to reduce the practice

28. Sellars famously dismantled the idea that there is something *given* at the foundation of knowing (the “Myth of the Given”). Any epistemological entity must be inferential and thus part of a linguistic network. The other side of the coin is another rejection: the semantic given. For more, see Wilfrid Sellars, “Empiricism and the Philosophy of Mind,” *Minnesota Studies in the Philosophy of Science* 1 (1956): 253–329. This essay was initially presented at the University of London under the title “The Myth of the Given: Three Lectures on Empiricism and the Philosophy of Mind.”

and language of one well-functioning domain to something that is deemed more fitting through external considerations.

Further problems emerge with colligatory notions. Virtmajoki writes: “We could put together different items and suggest different trends and patterns, but this hardly establishes that the trends and patterns do not deserve realist interpretations as attempts to describe the mind-independent world” (40). What kind of realism might this be? If it is agreed that trends and patterns are composed of many elements, which can in turn be combined in numerous ways to compose alternative trends and patterns, then either we need an argument that one of them is uniquely correct or we need to accept that none is. Perhaps a particular composition counts as correct because it was produced in accordance with an accepted method of historiography. Naturally, there is an alternative too: All are equally correct, but this does not support the realist’s case. Could a historian then just create a colligation and claim that it is independently “real”? We need some epistemological criteria to distinguish “real” from “unreal.”

In the end, Virtmajoki’s call for an empirical turn is commendable: “We need to analyze *the historiographical practice, the whole historiographical practice, and nothing but the historiographical practice*” (45). It is pivotal to make a genuine analysis of historiography and not get lost in the mazes of philosophical abstractions. He is also right that anti-realism correlates with the observation that any historiographical account is contingent and inconclusive. This is well captured in the oft-quoted notion that every generation writes history again. However, although some philosophical accounts may be made plausible by way of empirical analyses, I am not sure that they can literally settle philosophical questions. If this is the intended meaning, then a change of perspective regarding the nature of philosophical problems is required.²⁹ Perhaps Virtmajoki means that we need more informed accounts of historiography in order to have relevant philosophical debates. With this I fully agree in any case.

REPRESENTATIONALISM

New Historical Realists tend to rely on metaphorical phrases and assumptions rather than on argumentation. For example, according to Timmins, “Roth needs to clarify how the knowledge-producing activities of historians ‘hook onto’ the past” (106). This is a demanding task, as it is not clear that any “hooking” takes place between those activities and the past. Minimally, this metaphor and the function of hooking should be explicated. At other times, one reads about “latching,” “counterparts,” and so on.

29. There is one promising philosophical orientation that may manage to bring the empirical and the philosophical (normative) together: neopragmatism and, in particular, functionalism, which understands philosophical notions in terms of their roles or functions. The intellectual trajectory leads back to Sellars. For further discussion, see Huw Price, *Facts and the Function of Truth*, extended ed. (Oxford University Press, forthcoming); Wilfrid Sellars, *The Metaphysics of Epistemology: Lectures by Wilfrid Sellars*, ed. Pedro Amaral (Ridgeview, 2012), esp. “Lecture 5: Meaning”; and Jouni-Matti Kuukkanen, *Doing, Knowing and Getting It Right: Methodologism as Pragmatism* (Cambridge University Press, 2026).

Mitrović begins his contribution titled “Historical Accuracy and Historians’ Objectivity” with an analysis of Leopold von Ranke’s dictum *wie es eigentlich gewesen* that focuses on the term *eigentlich*, which he translates as “actually” (53). As we have already seen, his peculiar interpretation is that realism is compatible with there being many equally accurate accounts of history without any one being *the* true account of the past. I have already shown that this is not a coherent account.

A plausible way to understand Ranke’s dictum is that, while there are, of course, many accounts of history on any particular object or episode of the past, only one of them describes how it really happened. This is a standard realist reading of Ranke’s idea.³⁰ If there are several accounts, they must be either false or compatible, creating, in effect, one larger account of history in the latter case. The historian’s job would be to find this true historical account. Our descriptions would then be the representations of the external (historian-independent) states of affairs. Representation can even be likened to a kind of mirror image, as Richard Rorty reminded us,³¹ but the foundational idea stays the same in any account that looks for a match or correspondence between a representation and a represented. Normally, a mirror represents only the represented. The representational form of correspondence appears to require some kind of morphological relation between narratives and the nonnarrative past. More generally, representationalism refers to a typical semantic approach, which attempts to determine the relation between language and the world. The history of these attempts is long, and its problems and limitations are now evident to anyone interested.³²

There is also a deep commitment to representationalism in Mitrović’s work. He frequently emphasizes the need for our expressions to “correspond,” have “counterparts,” or otherwise reference the external world. However, he oddly moves from these considerations to the issue of observational or predictive success, which has nothing to do with the correspondence functions. Archetypical instrumentalists and anti-realists, such as van Fraassen, build their whole theory on the idea of predictive success without realism. For this reason, Mitrović’s argument ends in a muddle.

I fully agree with Timmins that it would indeed be silly to imagine historical accounts as perfect reproductions or representations of the past. Do the book’s contributors perhaps then commit to anti-representational realism, which is also

30. However, this realist interpretation is complicated by the fact that Ranke followed the phrase *wie es eigentlich gewesen* by remarking, “there is an exalted ideal toward which we can reach: the event itself in its human intelligibility, its unity, its diversity. I know how far from it I have remained. One tries, one strives, but in the end it is not attained. Let none be impatient with this!” (“Introduction to the *History of the Latin and Teutonic Nations*,” in *The Secret of World History: Selected Writings on the Art and Science of History*, ed. Roger Wines [Fordham University Press, 1981], 58–59). Ranke appears to commit to epistemological anti-realism here. I thank Ethan Kleinberg for drawing my attention to the entire passage.

31. Richard Rorty, *Philosophy and the Mirror of Nature* (Princeton University Press, 1979).

32. See, for example, Robert B. Brandom, *Making It Explicit: Reasoning, Representing, and Discursive Commitment* (Harvard University Press, 1994) and Huw Price et al., *Expressivism, Pragmatism and Representationalism* (Cambridge University Press, 2013).

a possible conceptual solution?³³ This might be a particularly fitting conceptual option for a realist in the philosophy of historiography. However, this option is not taken; instead, the contributors fall back on the old problematic representational constellation. The key concept in New Historical Realism is “recapturing”—as in, “the realist argues that when circumstances are favorable, historians can be and are successful in recapturing what took place in the past” (6). On the face of it, “recapturing” is very similar to “representing.” How, what, and in what form *exactly* do we “recapture”?

FACTS AND POLITICAL IMPLICATIONS

Førland’s contribution titled “Postmodern Frankenstein; or, the Alternative Facts Monster” argues that facts are only relatively theory-laden so that a fact in one “theory” may be laden not by the theory it is part of but by another theory. This is a reasonable line of argumentation, one that was discussed decades ago in the history and philosophy of science under the rubrics of theory comparison, and in particular, as the dispute regarding whether comparing scientific theories always presupposes a background theory. This led to a debate about the incommensurability of scientific theories and paradigms, among other issues. According to Førland, “since many facts, in historiography as in other disciplines, are independent of the theory in which they form building blocks (though they may depend for their reliability on other theories, often within other disciplines such as paleography or ancient languages), they function as theory-independent information relative to the theory (and often the discipline) in question” (77). This is a promising approach in that facts are taken not as absolute but as relative and frame-dependent. Sets of facts would indeed seem to serve as a baseline that is independent of the theory they support.

But what does it mean to say that something is a “fact”? Compare the following: “‘This person has been proven to be biologically female.’ This conclusion seems then to have been established as a fact” (76). “Fact” here is a shorthand expression for “proven.” Unfortunately, taken literally, the word “proven” is too strong because it refers to a demonstration, with near certainty, that a proposition is true. Nevertheless, we can charitably understand Førland’s “fact” as an epistemic entity that is highly justified (“established”). This means that “facts” are not there sitting in the world but instead are outcomes of our judgments and evidential considerations.

Although Førland recognizes the main definitions of fact as a true proposition and as a state of affairs and complains about the elusiveness of “facts” in so-called postmodern discourse, he himself perhaps inadvertently puts forward a dynamic sociological notion of fact, albeit with rational constraints. It is symptomatic that Førland refers to the amount of evidence in the disagreement over whether there were more or fewer audience members at Donald Trump’s 2017 presidential inauguration than at Barack Obama’s four years earlier. Førland writes: “‘Facts’ in

33. Henrik Rydenfelt, “Realism Without Representationalism,” *Synthese* 198, no. 4 (2021): 2901–18.

my conception are statements that everyone of a sound mind would agree to or accept provided the persons are cognizant of the language and terms used and seriously and thoroughly investigate the phenomenon in question” (168). This makes agreement a definitional condition of facthood, relative to the persons’ linguistic competence and investigative efforts. Perhaps we might understand this as Nicholas Rescher’s ideal rationality³⁴ because its demand that “everyone of a sound mind” would consent is a strong requirement. C. S. Peirce’s idea that we come to an agreement at the end of all inquiry springs to mind too. According to Peirce, “all the followers of science are fully persuaded that the processes of investigation, if only pushed far enough, will give one certain solution to each question to which they can be applied.”³⁵

In accordance with this, Følrand states that facts are determined by expert consensus. In contrast to what Følrand says, “alternative fact” is, then, not a “contradiction in terms” (164). It only means that there is a serious disagreement about evidence (and/or perhaps a problem regarding linguistic competence and comprehension). Perhaps those talking about “alternative facts” are misguided about what evidence indicates. Participants in the debate may also have a different set of evidence at hand. Perhaps they disagree on what can be concluded on the basis of evidence—that is, a case of underdetermination of theory by evidence and potentially a problem with inferential reasoning too. Admittedly, Følrand’s conception may imply that evidence may compel acceptance of a certain proposition or that evidence suggests only one proposition, in which case it would be unreasonable to fathom such a disagreement. But this relates more to the issue of rationality, and of its universality, than to facts as some kind of metaphysical building blocks.

As Følrand himself also recognizes, this definition of facts does not guarantee the truth of the statements—that is, if one clings to the correspondence sense of truth. Facts are only contingently what they are and therefore are not truth-makers that exist independently of our conceptual activity, as required by his advocacy of the correspondence theory. To resolve this tension, he should either give up on the correspondence requirement or drop the consensus view of facts. In the latter case, facts become metaphysical entities. In the former case, they become fully epistemological and even sociological entities because their facticity is dependent on agreement. This is reminiscent of Latour’s definition of “fact,” according to which the status of agreed upon statements varies. Before their “black boxing” into “facts,” statements are assigned a number of negative and positive qualifications that indicate how firmly they have become part of a belief system.³⁶ When Følrand notes that no historian doubts that World War II is over or that Nazi

34. According to Rescher, “rationality is universal in the sense that anyone in just the same circumstances would be rationally well advised to adopt the same resolution” and “what is rational for one person is also rational for anyone else in his shoes” (*Rationality: A Philosophical Inquiry into the Nature and the Rationale of Reason* [Clarendon Press, 1988], 1, 158).

35. C. S. Peirce, “How to Make Our Ideas Clear,” *Popular Science Monthly* 12 (January 1878), 299. According to Peirce, “the opinion which is fated to be ultimately agreed to by all who investigate, is what we mean by the truth, and the object represented in this opinion is the real” (ibid., 300).

36. See Bruno Latour’s idea of facts as sociological entities and their various modal qualifications (*Science in Action: How to Follow Scientists and Engineers Through Society* [Harvard University Press, 1987]).

Germany lost (168), he is quite right. No sensible layperson doubts these either. But this does not lead to realism; it leads to evidentialism, or perhaps rationalism, with regard to what is accepted. In the end, it is the rules of a community governing potential agreement and disagreement that matter. Turning this position into realism requires an additional philosophical argument, which is nowhere found in his contribution.

Another interesting aspect of *The Poverty of Anti-Realism* is its attempt to connect anti-realism with political consequences. With the exception of Marxism, epistemological and ontological doctrines have typically not been thought to have immediate political consequences. Følrand discusses the recent history of so-called post-truth politics, and his essay contains some good philosophical insights. Strikingly, Følrand compares “postmodern discourse” about truth and falsity to Frankenstein’s monster, suggesting that the left-wing scholars helped to conceive this monster. He also makes the astonishing claim, and perhaps even accusation, that left-wing academics are closet positivists (177). This notwithstanding, he does not seem to realize that positivism does not take one to realism. Positivists, at least logical positivists, were anti-realists and the entire realism-anti-realism debate was meaningless metaphysics to them.

Verstegen’s contribution titled “Is Historical Anti-Realism (Ever) Politically Progressive?” provides another impressionist history in this volume. He discusses how anti-realism has allegedly been connected with politics since the 1930s. Unfortunately, he also shifts haplessly between anti-realism, relativism, and post-modernism without stipulating what exactly they are, how exactly they are related, and who exactly has advocated them in each context. Furthermore, he makes bold metaphysical statements without using his revisionist history to back it or without explaining how he has the ability to look at the matters from the God’s-eye point of view. For example, he claims that “it is the nature of philosophy that there will *always* be both historical realists and anti-realists” (141; emphasis added). Always? Really? How does he know this?

In Verstegen’s essay, we find imprecise or biased interpretations, which, unfortunately, is characteristic of the entire book. For example, my skepticism about whether colligatory concepts refer to individuals, as proper names do, and whether their organizing principles are object-sided and independent of the historian are understood as “denying the reality of an event, or the coherence of a period term like ‘the Renaissance.’” It is difficult to know how a term could even be coherent. More importantly, we repeatedly encounter this book’s magical term: “real,” or “reality.” One is asked to “*theorize* our stance toward that reality” (145) in a similar kind of way to how Weberman wished us to compare the accuracy and truth of our narratives to the “past reality.” This is no small feat!

Further, Verstegen recognizes that Hempel and his followers were not realists, but he states incorrectly that “historical realism lets us judge the strength of historical narratives on their merits” (155). How could this be? Realists wish to judge the reality of various narratives, colligations, events, and so on, and their relations to historical reality itself, rather than let the historiographical practice judge this on its own terms and merits. Verstegen’s essay contains some genuinely interesting claims, such as the claim that “relativism or anti-realism was just the result of

the politicization of epistemology within a shrunken horizon of activity of politics" (152), but these kinds of claims are not properly developed and justified.

Another skewed facet in *The Poverty of Anti-Realism* has to do with New Historical Realists mistakenly portraying anti-realism as a form of skepticism and even as an anything-goes approach. Naturally, some anti-realists may be skeptics, and some may also be relativists. However, in general, anti-realism is better characterized as exhibiting epistemic humility than skepticism. We may be wrong about the matters we analyze and investigate. This is also plausible because we have so often been wrong in the past. Interestingly, realists often write about fallibilism. But as soon as they state this, realists postulate firm statements about the nature of reality and our relation to it. By contrast, anti-realists typically emphasize that our particular ways of being in the world affect the kind of knowledge we produce about the world. If this is so, then it is only reasonable to be open to many descriptions of the world, perhaps even at the ideal limit of our inquiries, instead of identifying any contemporary description as the definitive one. This irreducible pluralism about the past and the world is one of the key elements in Nelson Goodman's irrealism, which Roth has applied in the philosophy of historiography.

In terms of political consequences, there is quite an opposite tendency to the perceived conservativeness of anti-realism. First, anti-realism, as epistemologically responsible pluralism, correlates with tolerance for alternative views of the world as well as with accepting one's fallibilism, but it still commits to evidential standards in assessing rival views. Second, claims regarding the "reality" and unique correctness of one's view may lead to authoritarian positions by demanding that others assent to a view that is only contingently true. This is something that Rorty warned about: We need epistemological humility instead of requiring assent to a view that is identified as objective. From the point of view of pragmatism, Følrand inadvertently highlights a crucial point. "Facts," as linguistic entities, bear significant performative power and political importance (173). This is why Trump also needs to refer to facts and alternative facts. They are powerful verbal weapons. The predicate of "factivity," as well as "reality," related to one's views brings power to the person and to that person's message. These weapons should be used responsibly, sparingly, and, importantly, with an awareness of their societal functions. Understanding their function in our language and practice is the most important thing.

A PLEA FOR PRUDENT SCHOLARSHIP IN PHILOSOPHY

In his critical analysis of anti-realism in the philosophy of historiography, Virmajoki provides an interesting criterion for the success of a philosophical argument: whether the argument provided manages to persuade someone who takes the opposite view. This is a noble aim. He concludes that anti-realists do not manage to persuade realists to abandon their positions. The same can be said of realists' arguments in the philosophy of historiography. Whereas Virmajoki claims that there is something missing in the argumentative strategies of anti-realism, the same can be said about realist strategies (37). Often, arguments are totally

missing from *The Poverty of Anti-Realism* and, in their place, we find a dogmatic and pre-analytical premise of realism's correctness. Too often New Historical Realists are so complacent about their philosophical assumptions that they seemingly do not care to justify them. The book includes too many inadequately developed arguments, misleading interpretations, and excessive assertions; there is too much unwarranted confidence.

My view is that we should aim to have a meaningful exchange despite all our limitations and biases and the lack of an ideal argumentative situation. Nonetheless, too many contributions to *The Poverty of Anti-Realism* exhibit a lack of understanding about the basic issues of realism and anti-realism and contain too many conceptual confusions. Philosophical notions, such as anti-realism, irrealism, postmodernism, idealism, and constructivism, are used sloppily and even interchangeably. Indeed, one of the most egregious errors of the book is its conceptual obscurity and impreciseness. Too often this book obfuscates rather than clarifies. The aim of improving philosophical understanding and dialogue is not going to be realized in this way; this practice risks creating a compromised model of scholarship in the philosophy of historiography.

In their introduction to *The Poverty of Anti-Realism*, Førland and Mitrović convey the sense that their "minority position" in the field has been discriminated against by editors and reviewers of other philosophical persuasions. Given that realism is the dominant position in the philosophy of science, this is akin to the United States complaining that it has been treated unfairly in international trade. In any case, they have now made so much noise that they are getting their reviews.

There are, of course, some glimmers of light and more measured approaches in the book, but they cannot balance the blatant negatives. *The Poverty of Anti-Realism* has too many contributions that should have been more philosophically informed and stylistically toned down. They simply should have been rewritten. I emphasize that realism is a respectable conceptual option in the philosophy of historiography, although it is not novel or fresh in historiography, or beyond. If one wishes to argue for it, one must outline a careful argument and engage with its rivals, reading existing scholarship with the intention of genuinely understanding it rather than merely to score points and win quick victories. It is troubling that many terms are provided with meanings that seemingly have not taken into consideration how they are understood and used in scholarship. This introduces numerous intellectual tensions, as I have tried to show.

In sum, *The Poverty of Anti-Realism* is very thin in argumentation and seems to be designed to polemicize and provoke by constructing overgeneralized categories and attempting to shift the burden of argumentation onto the perceived enemies. The broad-brush categories are premised on an us-against-them view of the scholarly debate, with "us" representing the voice of good, reason, intellectual rigor, and facts and "them" representing everything to be objected to and deficient, having been presented in alarmist terms as dangerously misguided and intellectually detrimental. What does this remind one of? Populism.

It is my firm conviction that we do not need populist philosophy of history or historiography because it either does not respect key epistemic values of good scholarship or plays fast and loose with those conventions and concepts.

Therefore, I end this review article with a plea for prudent scholarship and reviewing in the philosophy of history and historiography, which naturally applies beyond this book and this exchange, and indeed to philosophy in general. To this end, I offer the following maxims:

- Use measured language and do not provoke unnecessarily.
- Be careful with concepts and their borders; do not blur the lines.
- Be honest in your scholarship and avoid providing self-serving and unfair characterizations of rival positions.
- Be consistent in your argumentation and do not contradict yourself.
- Be explicit in your argumentation, for mere intuition is not enough.
- Be learned and do not try to reinvent the wheel.
- Be modest: There is no need to elevate yourself and assume that you are correct and that others are fools.
- Be prepared to change your mind.

I have tried to follow these maxims in this review despite also feeling the responsibility to point out errors. The reader alone can judge how I have succeeded ethically and intellectually.

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